



2024 Summer EBT Implementation Report

**A Snapshot of Parent Experiences
from Three School Districts in Ohio**



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Executive Summary

In July 2024, Ohio launched the [Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer Program](#), or Summer EBT, also known as SUN Bucks. This new, permanent federal nutrition program - the first in nearly 50 years - aims to address the summer meal gap for children who receive free and reduced-price meals during the school year. Ohio is [one of 37 states](#) that opted into Summer EBT in its inaugural year.

The purpose of this research project was to learn more about how Summer EBT was implemented in Ohio in 2024, and most importantly, how the program impacted eligible families. Our ultimate goal was to collect parent experiences in order to make recommendations to the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (ODEW) and the Ohio Department of Job and Family Services (ODJFS) on how to strengthen the Summer EBT program in future years.



Summer EBT Benefits Logo
[Ohio Department of Jobs and Family Services](#)

Key Findings

1. Summer EBT provided critical nutrition assistance to **1.2 million** Ohio children in 2024, exceeding expectations.
2. Summer EBT infused over **\$118 million** in federal funding into local grocery stores, farmers' markets, and other SNAP retailers in all 88 counties across Ohio, with a total economic impact of over **\$182 million** in 2024.
3. Summer EBT benefits were spent quickly during the summer months, as intended. Within 3 months of initial Summer EBT payments, over **82%** of benefits had already been redeemed at local grocery stores.
4. The vast majority (98%) of children eligible for Summer EBT received benefits automatically, without their caregivers needing to fill out a separate application. This resulted in significant administrative savings and reduced stress for families.
5. Families interviewed for this study reported very positive experiences with Summer EBT in 2024. Families especially appreciated the timing of the benefits, ease of enrollment, and the dignity the program provides.
6. The school administrators interviewed found Summer EBT to operate more smoothly than the program's predecessor (Pandemic EBT) and was not overly burdensome for schools to participate.

7. Schools operating their National School Lunch Program under Community Eligibility or Provision 2 models need additional support and resources to clearly and consistently communicate with parents/families about Summer EBT eligibility and how to submit an application.
8. In 2024, the Ohio Departments of Education and Workforce and Job and Family Services did an extraordinary job standing up the nation's first new, permanent child nutrition program in 50 years on a very short timeline. To ensure the Summer EBT program reaches its full potential as it matures in 2025 and beyond, both agencies should be fully funded in Ohio's 2025 - 2026 biennium budget.

Background

The original [Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer for Children \(SEBTC\)](#) project was a pilot program authorized by Congress in 2010 (operated from 2011 through 2019) to reduce child hunger during the summer months. The pilot program tested different monthly benefit levels (ranging from \$30-\$60 per child) and was highly successful, with the highest benefit level reducing the most severe form of childhood food insecurity by one-third. The new permanent, nationwide Summer EBT program was created by Congress through the [Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2023](#) and built on the success of both the SEBTC pilot and the [Pandemic EBT](#) program during COVID-19. **Summer EBT is one of the few pandemic-era programs that Congress made permanent.**

“Out of all of the things that came out of the pandemic, [this program] was one that was meaningful. I think some [other pandemic programs] were off the mark, but this one made sense.”

- School District Administrator

During the 2023 - 2024 school year, there were around [1.9 million](#) school children (preschool through 12th grade) in Ohio and roughly [1.75 million](#) of them attended schools that participate in the National School Lunch Program (NSLP). In Federal Fiscal Year (FFY) 2023, [933,000](#) Ohio children participated in NSLP. Like the program's predecessors (SEBTC and Pandemic EBT), Summer EBT is expected to be far better at reaching eligible children than traditional summer meal sites alone, which reached [94,000](#) Ohio children in FFY23 - or *just 10% of children* who participated in NSLP during the same year.

In 2024, **Summer EBT provided all eligible children with \$120 per summer** (equivalent to \$40/month) to supplement their families' groceries bills when kids are home from school. Families can participate in both Summer EBT and the [Summer Meals Program](#), further increasing the nutrition support available to low-income children during school breaks.

Summer EBT benefits are 100% federally-funded, with states covering 50% of administrative costs. The program's design includes some key features that benefit families and minimize administrative costs at both the federal and state levels. **Most importantly, the program automatically enrolls the vast majority of eligible children** who are identified based on their participation in other means-tested programs, including the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), Ohio Works First (OWF), Medicaid (when income is below 185% FPL), and those who completed a free/reduced-price school meal application during the 2023 - 2024 school year. For children whose families are income-eligible but were not directly enrolled through one of these existing channels, there is an online [Summer EBT application](#).

“ It gives us an opportunity to take care of our families when we are in hardship or in need. It prevents a lot of us from slipping into depression because we can't get the things that we might need when the kids are home and it can become a little bit more difficult.”

- Cleveland Heights School District Parent

Methods

To achieve our research goals, the study team analyzed program implementation processes designed by state agency administrators, the perspectives of school district personnel, the experiences of parents and caregivers who received Summer EBT benefits, and quantitative data on program outcomes. Public data requests to the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (ODEW) and the Ohio Department of Job and Family Services (ODJFS) yielded helpful information and operating plans, which allowed the study team to construct a timeline (see [“Figure 1: Ohio's Summer EBT Timeline” on page 5](#)) of planned and actual implementation of the program.

To gather experiences from parents and caregivers, target school districts were selected as recruitment sites based on their unique characteristics to get diverse responses. Selected school districts differed in size, student demographics, and school food policy to represent some of the many ways that Summer EBT played out in Ohio. See [“Table 1: Target District and County Profiles” on page 6](#) for a summary of school district characteristics.

Once school districts were selected, outreach to potential district partners began. The study team contacted various school district leaders, including superintendents, school board members, family resource coordinators, and other departmental leads as potential research partners. The main objective of this outreach was to inform school leaders about the research project's goals, request permission to interview one or more administrators, and enlist their support to recruit parents and caregivers for key informant interviews.

Figure 1: Ohio's Summer EBT Timeline

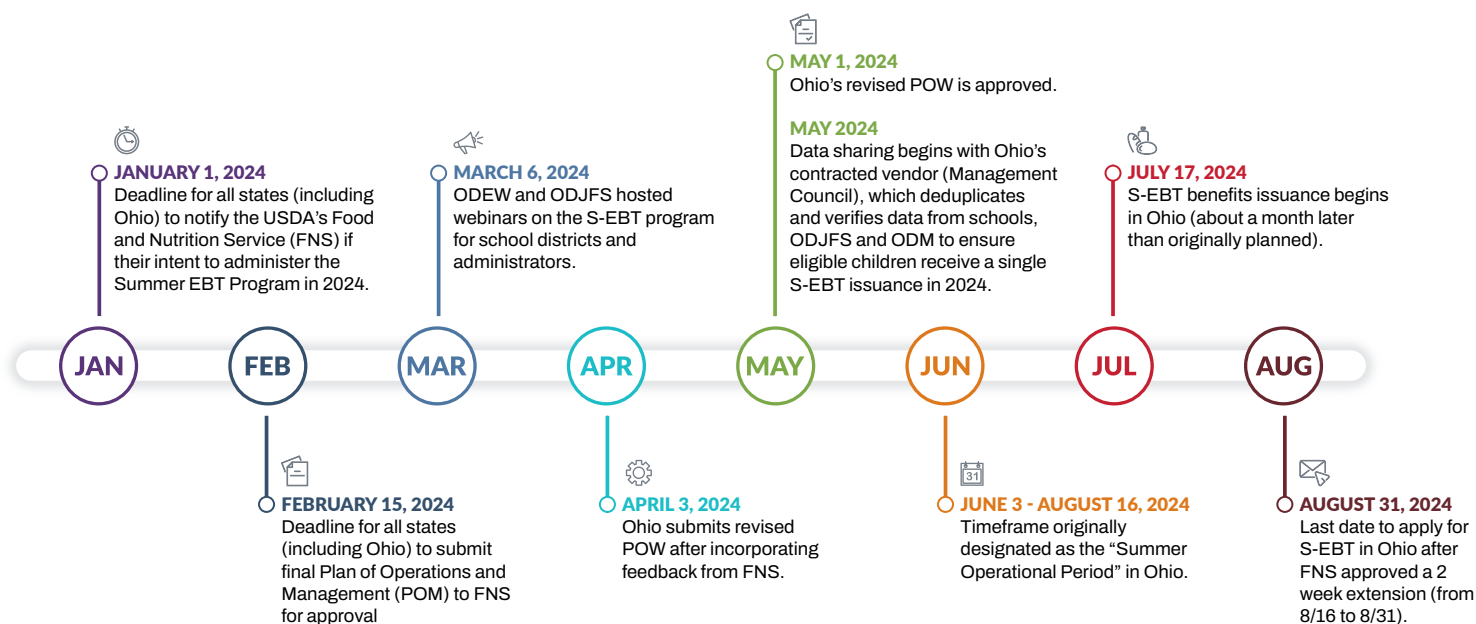


Table 1: Target District and County Profiles

Painesville City Local School district details (2023-2024 School Year) District Demographic Dashboard (2018-2022)	Chesapeake Union Exempted Village School district details (2023-2024 School Year) District Demographic Dashboard (2018-2022)	Cleveland Heights-University Heights School District Details (2023-2024 School Year) District Demographic Dashboard (2018-2022)
Lake County - Total schools: 5 - Total Students: 2,696 - Classroom Teachers (FTE): 159.20 - Student/Teacher Ratio: 16.93	Lawrence County - Total schools: 3 - Total Students: 1,222 - Classroom Teachers (FTE): 70.33 - Student/Teacher Ratio: 17.38	Cuyahoga County - Total Schools: 11 - Total Students: 4,916 - Classroom Teachers (FTE): 350.75 - Student/Teacher Ratio: 14.02
Community Demographics - Total population: 16,843 - Median household income: \$46,634 - Total households: 6,357 - Race & Ethnicity - White: 64% - Black/ Af-Am: 14% - Latino: 29% - Asian: 1% - American/Alaska Native: 0% - Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander: 0% - Other: 10% - Two or More: 11% - Households with Internet: 85.4% - Housing structures - House: 69.0% - Apartments/Other: 31.0%	Community Demographics - Total population: 6,858 - Median household income: \$67,799 - Total households: 2,801 - Race & Ethnicity - White: 94% - Black/ Af-Am: 2% - Latino: 0% - Asian: 1% - American/Alaska Native: 0% - Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander: 0% - Other: 0% - Two or More: 3% - Households with Internet: 87.5% - Housing structures - House: 74.8% - Apartments/Other: 25.1%	Community Demographics - Total population: 58,038 - Median household income: \$72,316 - Total households: 24,047 - Race & Ethnicity - White: 54% - Black/ Af-Am: 36% - Latino: 3% - Asian: 5% - American/Alaska Native: 0% - Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander: 0% - Other: 1% - Two or More: 3% - Households with Internet: 91% - Housing structures - House: 68.3% - Apartments/Other: 31.6%
Enrolled Student Demographics - Language spoken at home - English less than well: 7.7% - English very well: 25.1% - English only: 67.2% - Health - Disability: 5.4% - Health Insurance: 92.7% - Poverty & Benefits - Below the poverty line: 20.8% - SNAP participants: 25.4%	Enrolled Student Demographics - Language spoken at home - English less than well: 0% - English very well: 0% - English only: 100% - Health - Disability: 4.4% - Health Insurance: 93.8% - Poverty & Benefits - Below the poverty line: 5.1% - SNAP participants: 6.9%	Enrolled Student Demographics - Language spoken at home - English less than well: 1.6% - English very well: 5.3% - English only: 93.1% - Health - Disability: 5.6% - Health Insurance: 97.8% - Poverty & Benefits - Below the poverty line: 17.3% - SNAP participants: 34.2%
Parents of Enrolled Children - Median household income: \$60,185 - Housing status - Renter: 59.0% - Owner: 41.0% - Labor force status: 77% in labor force - Educational attainment - Less than high school: 36.9% - High school graduate: 36.0% - Some college/AA degree: 20% - Bachelors or higher: 7.1%	Parents of Enrolled Children - Median household income: \$86,239 - Housing status - Renter: 11.4% - Owner: 88.6% - Labor force status: 89% in labor force - Educational attainment - Less than high school: 6.3% - High school graduate: 18.3% - Some college/AA degree: 27.4% - Bachelors or higher: 48%	Parents of Enrolled Children - Median household income: \$72,998 - Housing status - Renter: 33.7% - Owner: 66.3% - Labor force status: 84% in the labor force - Educational attainment - Less than high school: 6.6% - High school graduate: 13.2% - Some college/AA degree: 32.8% - Bachelors or higher: 47.5%

Parent and Caregiver Recruitment

After locating research sites and securing recruitment support from school leaders, the study team designed recruitment flyers in English and Spanish with details about the paid research study (see [“Appendix 1” on page 18](#)). Research site partners directly supported recruitment efforts by contacting caregivers to gauge interest or placing flyers on campus for parents to see. Interested participants either consented to have their contact information shared with the study team for follow-up or contacted the study team directly.

Upon initial contact with potential participants, the research team explained the study details, including how interviewees would be compensated and the voluntary nature of their participation. For some participants, this information was included in a follow-up email where they provided informed consent in writing. For all participants, study details were reiterated at the outset of each interview and participants provided verbal consent.

Most interviews were conducted virtually via the Zoom Video Meeting platform. Some interviews were completed via telephone calls and were recorded by Zoom. Interviews ranged from 20 to 50 minutes long and were semi-structured in nature. An interview protocol (see [“Appendix 2” on page 19](#)) created by the research team primarily guided these conversations, but unprompted follow-up questions, anecdotes, and information exchanges occurred throughout the interviews.

At the end of each interview, participants were compensated according to their preferences. Participants received \$100 electronically (e.g. Venmo, Zelle), in paper checks mailed to their address, or in gift cards to a major retailer (Target, Amazon, Walmart, etc.) of their choosing. The Rev.com platform generated transcripts that were manually reviewed and revised by a member of the research team. Direct quotes, response patterns, and key insights were extracted from these interviews using thematic coding. Key findings from interviews and the program analysis are summarized in the Findings section that follows.

Administrator interviews followed a similar process, except their interviews utilized a different interview protocol (See [“Appendix 3” on page 20](#)) with questions meant to capture details about program implementation within their districts. Administrator interviews included verbal informed consent, a semi-structured questioning format, Zoom recordings, and Rev.com transcripts. School administrators did not receive compensation for interviews.

Research efforts included outreach to community organizations as well. The [Ohio Association of Foodbanks](#) provided important insight into issues parents and caregivers had while trying to access the program. The [Greater Cleveland Food Bank](#) supported recruitment efforts and offered to provide translations.

Findings

This research effort resulted in many important positive findings, as well as a few notable challenges with Ohio's first year implementation of Summer EBT. For the sake of brevity, these findings are detailed in bullet points below:

Implementation Findings

1. Summer EBT benefits reached an incredible 1.2 million Ohio children in 2024, far surpassing the original estimate of 841,000 children included in Ohio's initial Plan of Operation and Management (POM). The most likely explanations for this over-performance are:
 - a. Ohio's successful implementation of [Medicaid direct certification](#) as part of the National School Lunch Program during the 2023-2024 school year.
 - b. Ohio's implementation of streamlined certification, which automatically included all children of compulsory school age (as defined by the state) in current SNAP households, as required by USDA's [Interim Final Rule on Summer EBT](#).

“ It most definitely helped with the cost of groceries and I was able to provide more food for the kids for the summer.”

- Chesapeake Union School District Parent

2. Summer EBT infused over **\$118 million** in federal funding into local grocery stores, farmers' markets, and other SNAP retailers in all 88 counties across Ohio, boosting the local economy. Because Summer EBT benefits are equivalent to SNAP from the retailer perspective, it is reasonable to assume that SNAP's well-established [economic multiplier](#) applies. For this reason, the study team estimates that **Summer EBT's total economic impact for Ohio's economy was \$182 million in 2024**.
3. Ohio succeeded in making Summer EBT benefits available to families during the Summer Operational Period - something that [other states struggled to accomplish](#). Initial payments began in mid-July with nearly all eligible families receiving benefits by early August. (See [“Figure 1: Ohio's Summer EBT Timeline” on page 5](#)).
 - a. Families quickly spent the food benefits they received, as intended by Congress. As of November 2024 (approximately 4 months after the first S-EBT benefits were issued), over **82%** of benefits had already been redeemed at local grocery stores.
4. The vast majority (98%) of children eligible for Summer EBT received benefits automatically, without their caregivers needing to fill out a separate application. This resulted in significant administrative savings and reduced stress for families.

5. School administrators interviewed for this study found Summer EBT to operate much more smoothly in 2024 than the program's predecessor (Pandemic EBT). For example, school districts that received hundreds of parent questions and complaints during Pandemic EBT implementation received "a few dozen or less" parent complaint calls in 2024.
 - a. Notably, the [Education Management Information System](#) (EMIS) coordinators responsible for interacting with ODEW and the state's data vendor (Management Council) to provide student data for Summer EBT did not find the program's requirements to be overly burdensome. Even so, school data professionals did have concrete recommendations about how data sharing for Summer EBT can continue to evolve and mature in future years, such as creating more integration between school food service data and Summer EBT's file upload platform to allow for more "real time" updates to school data.

 I love the program. I love knowing that we're helping families."

- School District Administrator

6. Schools operating their National School Lunch Program under the Community Eligibility Provision (CEP) or Provision 2 model need additional support and resources to clearly and consistently communicate with parents and caregivers about Summer EBT eligibility and how to complete an application.
 - a. During year 1 implementation, messaging to potentially-eligible families who needed to complete a Summer EBT application was very limited. Some CEP schools shared information with parents via email and on the school website (see [here](#), [here](#), and [here](#)), and some community-based organizations (led by the Ohio Association of Foodbanks) stepped up to [share information](#) with the families they serve. Ultimately, Ohio only received 6,800 Summer EBT applications in 2024, more than half of which were denied due to ineligibility.
 - b. Most caregivers interviewed for this study mentioned relying on social media (especially Facebook) and smartphone apps for managing benefits (especially Propel) for information about Summer EBT. Only a few interviewed parents remembered receiving any information from their school district about the program.
 - c. Children in CEP and Provision 2 districts who receive SNAP or OWF benefits, as well as foster children and those who are unhoused, received Summer EBT benefits automatically. All other income-eligible children in these districts needed to apply, which was a change from how the Pandemic EBT program worked. The CEP districts interviewed for this study reported some complaints from parents whose children did not receive benefits but thought they should have, primarily because they were unaware of the application requirement.

Caregiver Interview Findings

1. Overall, the Summer EBT-eligible families interviewed for this study reported very positive experiences with the program in 2024. **Parents and caregivers especially appreciated** the following aspects of the Summer EBT program:
 - a. **The timing of Summer EBT benefits.** Participating families were grateful that Summer EBT provided extra nutrition assistance during the three months when kids are home for summer and eating more groceries.
 - ii. Most interviewed caregivers said the benefits would have been even more helpful if they would have arrived earlier in the summer (e.g. in June) rather than near the end of the summer (e.g. late July/early August).
 - iii. The caregivers we spoke to were divided on whether a single lump sum payment of \$120 vs. smaller monthly payments (\$40/month for 3 months) during the summer would be more beneficial in the future.
 - b. **The simplicity of program enrollment**, based on their children's participation in other means-tested programs (like SNAP, Medicaid, and free/reduced-price school meals). Interviewed caregivers described what a relief it was to receive extra grocery support without having to jump through new administrative hoops to access it, especially given the relatively modest benefit amount per child.
 - c. **The flexibility to purchase nutritious food that would meet their children's individual dietary needs and preferences.** Several interviewed caregivers described medical conditions and/or food sensitivities that limit what food their children can eat, so the flexibility to grocery shop for themselves (vs. receiving food from a local food pantry) was important. Notably, the most commonly reported food purchased with Summer EBT benefits among those interviewed was fresh fruit.

“We changed our entire lifestyle during the summer and instead of buying the foods I would normally buy, which are cheaper, I started purchasing healthier foods and budgeting for healthier foods.”

- Painesville School District Parent

- d. **The convenience of spending Summer EBT benefits at the same grocery retailers that accept SNAP.** Summer EBT's interoperability with SNAP benefits helped families save on transportation costs. Interviewed caregivers reported travel times between two and 20 minutes required to reach their preferred grocery retailer that accepts EBT.

- e. **The reliability of the Summer EBT benefit.** Interviewed families appreciated the flexibility and dignity that Summer EBT provides. Families also described Summer EBT as a much more reliable way to meet their children’s nutritional needs compared to traditional summer meal sites where kids can be turned away if the site runs out of food for the day or only serves children from a particular zip code.
- f. **The inclusion of more families in Summer EBT than typically qualify for SNAP benefits.** Several interviewed caregivers with full-time jobs were grateful for the extra help from Summer EBT, despite no longer qualifying for SNAP benefits due to increased earnings.

“Summer EBT definitely helped during the summer when my kids are home more and eating more. It definitely saved us from eating Top Ramen every night.”

- Painesville School District Parent

- 2. When asked about the name of the new program, study participants were split on whether the program should be marketed as “Summer EBT” or “SUN Bucks” in 2025 and beyond.
 - a. Those in rural areas and those not already enrolled in SNAP generally preferred “SUN Bucks,” saying that the program feels less stigmatizing without the term “EBT” in the name. Another respondent felt SUN Bucks was better because it is more clearly distinct from Pandemic EBT, which had different eligibility rules (most notably for students attending CEP schools).
 - b. By contrast, other interviewed caregivers preferred “Summer EBT” as the program’s name because it’s very clear (i.e. “EBT benefits for the summer”) and less likely to confuse automatically enrolled families, who may think SUN Bucks is a different program, causing them to waste time figuring out how to apply.
- 3. Interviewed caregivers had few concerns with the program overall, but did offer several specific suggestions to state agency leaders about how to improve Summer EBT in future years.
 - a. **Better communication on card delivery** for the 618,661 children whose benefits were deposited on a new Summer EBT card, rather than an existing Ohio Direction (SNAP) card.¹
 - i. One interviewed caregiver commented that other parents who don’t already receive SNAP benefits did not know Summer EBT cards were coming in the mail in a non-descript envelope, which they inadvertently threw out thinking it was junk mail. This caregiver suggested having schools distribute cards to eligible children as they are

1 Public Records Request, Ohio Department of Job and Family Services (ODJFS), October 2024.

leaving for the summer. *Note: Ohio's approved Plan of Operation and Management included the option for schools to distribute cards to children with no known address, including unhoused and foster children.*

- b. **Distribution of S-EBT benefits earlier in the summer**, closer to when school ends (e.g. June), so parents aren't having to wait for that extra grocery support.
- c. **Make the card activation process easier**, especially for those who struggle with automated systems and/or speak a first language other than English. One parent also recommended establishing or better publicizing ways to check the S-EBT card balance without having to call the confusing EBT hotline. One way to do this could be to promote trusted EBT apps on the buck slips mailed to parents, along plain language instructions on card activation.
- d. **Reduce the delay between Summer EBT card delivery and benefits posting** to the child's account. In 2024, some caregivers received S-EBT cards that were "empty" because benefits had not yet been posted to their account, which caused some confusion and concern.
- e. **Encourage more frequent communication from schools about Summer EBT benefits and how to apply.** One interviewed parent suggested that schools send notices early in the school year - ideally with other beginning of the year paperwork - and then send reminder notices closer to the end of the school year to ensure all eligible families have applied and addresses are up to date. These reminders are most important for families who need to apply and those who don't already get SNAP benefits.
- f. **Provide higher benefit amounts per child**, given the rising cost of food, and **extend the time available to spend Summer EBT benefits.** Several caregivers noted that it would be nice to be able to save S-EBT benefits for true emergencies that can happen throughout the year when living paycheck to paycheck (e.g. lost job, big car repair bill, etc.), rather than having to spend the benefits as soon as you get them. *Note: Although both of these policy decisions are not within Ohio's control, it's important to continue elevating parent perspectives' to inform national policy discussions.*

“It felt like they [the State of Ohio] thought about the kids more. They understood kids will be home. That more families that already need assistance may need a little extra assistance. I think ya'll are onto a good thing.”

- Cleveland Heights School District Parent

Caregiver and Household Demographics

While the interview sample in this study is far too small to be considered representative, it does reflect some of the most common profiles of eligible households in Ohio. Out of 12 interviewed caregivers:

- Most respondents were women (11) between the ages of 30 and 39 (9). One respondent was a grandmother with custody of her grandchildren.
- All interviewed households spoke English as their primary language.
- A majority of respondents identified as white (8), three identified as Black and/or African American, and two identified as Mixed-race.
- One respondent shared that members of their household received disability benefits; Two other respondents had children with disabilities who were not yet receiving disability benefits.
- Most households (8) had employment income, including three households with multiple working adults. Among households with earned income, four were below 100% of the federal poverty line (FPL), two had incomes between 100% and 130% FPL, and two had incomes between 130% and 200% FPL.
- The households interviewed for this study included 30 children who received Summer EBT benefits in Summer 2024, ranging in age from 7 to 16. This includes 19 elementary students, 8 middle school students, and 3 high schoolers.



Research Limitations

There are several limitations to this community-based research effort that are important to acknowledge.

1. Short timeframe to outreach to parents and caregivers.

- a. Given the scale and nature of the project, we were limited to school districts and families that were able to engage with the research team relatively quickly to share information and schedule interviews.
- a. In accordance with the original research protocol (see [“Appendix 5” on page 22](#)), the study team was able to collect enough information to better understand program implementation, but the data collection was not comprehensive enough to draw overarching conclusions about all recipients’ experience with Summer EBT.

2. Unsuccessful recruitment of Spanish-speaking parents and caregivers.

- a. Despite many attempts to recruit caregivers who speak a language other than English at home - especially in the Painesville school district where approximately one-third of parents speak Spanish at home - we were unsuccessful.
- b. There are many possible reasons for this, including a national election that happened during our recruitment period that included negative attacks against immigrants. Given this context, the study team fully respected the decision by several community-based groups that we engaged to not participate in the research project.

3. Insufficient number of interviews with families who needed to submit a Summer EBT application to qualify.

- a. Given that the vast majority of Summer EBT participants in 2024 were directly enrolled in the program, it’s unsurprising that it turned out to be difficult to openly recruit interview participants who used the much less common application pathway to enroll in Summer EBT benefits. (One interviewed caregiver did submit and track her S-EBT application online, but ultimately got enrolled through direct issuance.)

4. In future research, it will be important to pursue additional feedback from groups that are not represented in this study, including:

- a. Caregivers with Limited English proficiency
- b. School districts and families in northwest and southwest Ohio
- c. Families who received Summer EBT benefits only after submitting an application (vs. those directly enrolled)

With these important caveats, the study team is extremely grateful to the three school districts who agreed to partner with us on this important research to help us gather these timely findings.

Because Summer EBT is still being designed for the future, now is the time to capture initial lessons - however incomplete they may be - for state leaders to incorporate, before program design details are finalized and much more difficult to change.

Recommendations

The ultimate goal of this research effort was to better understand first year implementation of the Summer EBT program in Ohio in order to craft recommendations for state leaders at the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (ODEW) and the Ohio Department of Job and Family Services (ODJFS).

Based on interviews with 15 caregivers and school administrators interviewed for this project, the Center for Community Solutions respectfully submits the following recommendations of ways to strengthen Ohio's Summer EBT program in 2025 and beyond -

- 1. Improve communication about Summer EBT for families in schools with community eligibility** (meaning in schools where individual applications for free or reduced-price meals are not collected because the school serves free meals to all students).
 - a. Provide program information and application materials – both in print and online – in at least the top 10 languages spoken in Ohio.
 - b. Share information with parents multiple times during the school year for families who need to apply for Summer EBT benefits, including early in the year, when the Summer EBT application opens, and near the end of the school year.
- 2. Improve the clarity of information provided to parents by the Summer EBT Hotline** (operated by Management Council) to encourage parents not already on the S-EBT eligibility list to submit an S-EBT application before the deadline, rather than suggesting that their school may have made a mistake by leaving them off the enrollment file.
 - a. To ensure parents receive accurate and timely information about Summer EBT benefits without excessive wait times, the **Summer EBT Hotline must be adequately funded, staffed, and trained**, including to serve parents with Limited English Proficiency and/or disabilities.
- 3. Issue Summer EBT benefits earlier in the summer** (e.g. June) rather than late July or early August. A few interviewed parents mentioned needing to rely on food pantries to supplement their children's nutritional needs while waiting for Summer EBT benefits to load.

4. **Ensure mailed Summer EBT cards and the “buck slips” mailed with them include information (“taglines”) in multiple languages** so all eligible families have the information they need to activate their Summer EBT card and utilize the benefits.
5. **Improve the data infrastructure for Summer EBT over time**, including giving school districts the ability to update student data in real time and integrate Summer EBT with existing school information systems, rather than schools having to wait for a few limited windows of time to submit a “flat file” to the state. Doing so will require intentional planning and targeted investments upfront, but will streamline program administration in the long term.
 - a. In future years, Ohio should consider collecting and analyzing demographic information associated with Summer EBT applications to better understand how to increase the number of Summer EBT applications from eligible children and reduce the percentage of application denials.
6. **Ensure the state agencies’ tasked with implementing Summer EBT are adequately funded** so they can continue operating one of the nation’s most successful Summer EBT programs.
 - a. Funding allocations should include sufficient resources for third-party partners operating the Summer EBT Hotline (e.g. to reduce peak wait times) and for community partners leading Summer EBT education and outreach efforts across the state.
 - b. One best practice from other states that Ohio could incorporate is creating a formal education and outreach plan for Summer EBT. Doing so could allow for the creation of more multi-lingual materials, as well as providing additional funding to school districts and community partners to help educate families about Summer EBT to raise awareness, reduce confusion, and increase the application approval rate.

“ I think what you guys have done, you hit a home run with it... I’m glad to see that somebody is taking the initiative to actually help families out.”

- Chesapeake Union School District Parent

Acknowledgements

This rapid response research project would not have been possible without the collaboration of many key partners and stakeholders throughout Ohio. First and foremost, we are grateful to the parents and caregivers who participated in this research effort by sharing their personal experiences with the Summer EBT program in 2024 and developing the recommendations to state agency leaders presented here. Their wisdom and insight was invaluable, and we look forward to continuing to collaborate with them as we begin sharing this research in the months ahead.

The research team would also like to acknowledge the many contributions of our school district partners at the Chesapeake Union School District, Cleveland Heights-University Heights School District, and Painesville City School District. Leaders in all three school districts understood the value of the Summer EBT program and the importance of lifting up the voices of parents and district administrators with the most nuanced understanding of how the program worked in 2024 and how it could be strengthened in the future.

We also want to thank the Ohio Association of Food Banks for providing critical information and feedback to help inform the aims of this research study and help answer questions when we ran into roadblocks. The Ohio Association of Food Banks and their vast partner network throughout Ohio have always been and will continue to be essential access points for Ohioans facing food insecurity, and trusted sources of information on critical programs like SNAP and Summer EBT.

Finally, we would like to thank the funding community that recognized the uniqueness of the first year of Summer EBT implementation as a learning opportunity and stepped up to provide funding for this research effort. These funding partners include the Healthy Lakewood Foundation, the George Gund Foundation, the Cleveland Foundation, the Mt. Sinai Foundation, and the John Corlett Rapid Response Fund at the Center for Community Solutions.

Summer EBT Paid Research Study: English/Spanish Recruitment Flyers

[View Full Document Here](#)

PAID RESEARCH STUDY

Summer EBT/SUN Bucks Program in Ohio

The Center for Community Solutions wants your ideas on how to make Summer EBT work better for families so we can make recommendations to Ohio leaders

WHO?

Parents and caregivers of school-age children eligible for Summer EBT benefits in 2024

WHAT?

30-60 minute interviews to learn about your family's experience with Summer EBT / SUN Bucks

WHERE?

Virtual (Zoom), in-person, or telephone interviews

WHEN?

October and November 2024



Research participants will be paid \$50-\$100, based on the length of the interview (30 to 60 minutes)

Email Rachel Cahill at rachel@rcahillconsulting.com for more information



Interview Protocol for Parents and Caregivers

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Semi-Structured Interview Protocol for Parents and Caregivers

As of October 1, 2024

Hi, my name is [NAME]. I work with the Center for Community Solutions, a nonprofit organization in Ohio dedicated to strengthening health and human services programs, like SNAP, Medicaid, and Summer EBT.

Thank you for agreeing to share your family's experience with Summer EBT benefits (also referred to as Sun-Bucks) with me today. As a reminder, this is a voluntary interview. Feel free to skip any question we ask. We can stop the conversation at any time. Participating in this survey will not impact your current or future eligibility for benefits in any way.

Do you have any questions before we begin?

1. How did you and your family first learn about the 2024 Summer EBT program?

a. (If options are needed, here are some examples with short-hand for coding)

- From my child's school or district ("school communication")
- From family members or friends ("word-of-mouth")
- From state/county JFS office ("state communication")
- When I got a Summer EBT card in the mail ("EBT card arrival")
- When I got extra money on my SNAP card ("SNAP card deposit")
- I got Pandemic EBT in the past and thought this was the same thing
- Other (please describe): _____

2. Did one or more children in your household get Summer EBT benefits in 2024?

a. (Possible answers; Ask for more detail if not initially offered)

- Yes, for all children in the household
- Yes, but only for some children in the household
- No, for all children in the household
- I don't know
- I'm still waiting to find out if one or more children in the household will get Summer EBT benefits
- Other (please describe): _____

Interview Protocol for School Administrators

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Semi-Structured Interview Protocol for School Administrators

October 2024

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Hi, my name is [NAME]. I work with the Center for Community Solutions, a nonprofit organization in Ohio dedicated to strengthening health and human services programs, like SNAP, Medicaid, and Summer EBT. Thank you for agreeing to share your experience with Summer EBT as a school administrator.

1. Can you start by telling us a little bit about the school district you work for, your role, and how you interacted with the Summer EBT program in 2024 (if at all)?
2. How was the school/district informed about the Summer EBT program from the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (ODEW)?
 - a. Did you find the information provided sufficient and clear?
2. How effective was the communication between the school district and the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (e.g. related to data submission or other necessary information-sharing)?
 - a. Were there any challenges in this communication?
 - b. Did anything in this communication work especially well? (e.g. lessons learned from Pandemic EBT)?
3. What data did the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce request from your school/district pertaining to Summer EBT?
 - a. Were there any challenges in providing that data to the state?
 - b. (If applicable): When additional free/reduced-price applications were submitted to your school/district by families, was there a way to send updated information to the state?
4. How did the school/district communicate Summer EBT information to families?
 - a. Was messaging sent to families from the district, from individual schools, or both (or neither)?
 - b. Did the school/district use state-created materials or create their own materials for families?
5. Did the school/district receive questions about Summer EBT from families?

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Informed Consent Form

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Summer EBT Research Informed Consent

October 2024

The Center for Community Solutions is a nonprofit organization in Ohio working to strengthen health and human services programs, like SNAP, Medicaid, and Summer EBT.

Summer EBT (also called SUN Bucks), is a new program that started in 2024. Summer EBT is similar to the Pandemic EBT program that operated from 2020-2023, but has some key differences. We are conducting interviews to better understand the experiences of Ohio families and schools during the first year of the program. We plan to use this information to make the program better for Ohio families and schools.

If you agree to participate, we will schedule a 30 or 60 minute interview with you to learn about your family's experience with Summer EBT. Interviews will be held virtually (via Zoom), by telephone, or in-person, if you prefer. The interview is voluntary. You can choose to skip any questions you don't want to answer and we can stop the conversation at any time. Right after completing the interview, you will receive a payment (between \$50 and \$100 based on the length of your interview) using cash, check, Venmo, or gift card, based on your preference.

Participating in this study will not affect your current or future eligibility for Summer EBT or any other benefits in any way. Any information that you share with us is confidential and will only be used for this research. We will not share your name or any other personal information that could be used to identify you as a research participant.

If you have any questions about the interview or the research project overall, please contact the project's lead researcher, Rachel Cahill at rachel@rcahillconsulting.com.

Please use the links below to schedule a virtual, in-person, or telephone interview. Please specify which interview format you prefer in the scheduling form.

- Schedule a [30-minute interview here](#)
- Schedule a [60-minute interview here](#)

Participant name

Date

Comprehensive Research Protocol

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Comprehensive Summer EBT Research Protocol

Updated October 1, 2024

Research Project Overview

Title: Building a Human-Centered Summer EBT Program: Lessons and Recommendations from First Year Implementation in Ohio

Purpose: To conduct original research and analysis on the first year of Summer EBT implementation in Ohio in order to provide evidence-based recommendations to the Ohio Department of Education and Workforce (ODEW), the Ohio Department of Job and Family Services (ODJFS), and the Ohio Governor's Office on opportunities to improve the program in 2025 and beyond.

The overarching goal of the project is to ensure children and families across Ohio, including in Community Eligibility districts, have equitable access to Summer EBT benefits. The research team is especially focused on better understanding which parts of Summer EBT implementation did and did not work well for parents and caregivers, as well as school administrators, to inform state recommendations.

Background: In July 2024, Ohio launched the [Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer Program](#) for Children, also known as SUN Bucks. This new, permanent federal nutrition program aims to address the summer meal gap for children who receive free and reduced-price meals during the school year. Ohio is [one of 37 states](#) that opted into Summer EBT in its inaugural year. Summer EBT is projected to reach [840,000 children](#) in 2024, approximately 30% of whom live in Northeast Ohio.

Key features of Summer EBT:

- Provides a one-time benefit of \$120 per eligible child to purchase groceries
- Can be used at grocery stores, farmers markets, and other authorized SNAP retailers
- Directly enrolls most eligible children, including those participating in SNAP, Ohio Works First (OWF), Medicaid (when income is below 185% FPL), or those who complete a free/reduced-price school meal application
- Income-eligible families (below 185% FPL) whose children are not directly enrolled can [apply](#)
- Benefits are loaded onto existing SNAP ("Ohio Direction") card or new Summer EBT card
- Funds expire 122 days after issuance

Summer EBT was created after the success of [Pandemic EBT](#) during COVID-19 and is one of the few successful pandemic-era programs that Congress made permanent. As was learned from the program's predecessor, Summer EBT is far better at reaching eligible children than traditional summer meal sites alone (which are still critical, but historically reach only 10% of eligible kids each summer). Families can participate in both Summer EBT and the [Summer Meals Program](#), further increasing nutrition support during school breaks.